

The Estimator

Turns a customer's request into a priced, winnable quote — fast enough to beat competitors, accurate enough to protect margin.

PRE-PRODUCTION

“ We sell a service, not just a part — my job is to know what it will really cost to make it before anyone touches a machine.

WHO THEY ARE

The Estimator translates drawings, models, and vague verbal requests into a manufacturing plan — material, operations, machine time, outside processing, and cost. They live at the very front of the shop's workflow, where nothing is billable yet and speed competes directly with accuracy: quote too slowly and a competitor wins the job; quote too cheaply and the shop loses money once it's won.

In small shops this is the owner doing it between everything else. In larger shops it's a dedicated seat — sometimes an entry-level engineer — who leans heavily on templates and past jobs to move fast.

A DAY IN THE LIFE

- RFQ in** An RFQ lands by email, customer portal, or automated quoting tool. **Logs it in a tracker** and makes a bid / no-bid call based on fit and shop capacity.
- Scope** Reviews the print and model — **quantity, tolerances, finish, flagged notes** like masking or cosmetic class.
- Build** Copies a similar past estimate for speed, or builds from scratch — picks the value stream and **lays out the operations**.
- Cost** Sources material and outside-processing prices, sets **setup and cycle-time targets**, applies labor, overhead, and markup.
- Send** Gut-checks price against the market, routes for a **second-person review**, then generates the quote PDF and emails it.

SNAPSHOT

Workflow stage	Pre-production
Also known as	Sales / Estimator
Reports toward	Sales / Owner
Speed target	~2–3 min / quote*
Work is billable?	No — pre-sale

ENVIRONMENT & TECH COMFORT

Desk-based, dual-monitor, mouse-and-keyboard. Fluent in CAD viewers, spreadsheets, and quoting tools. Comfortable with software — this is a knowledge-worker seat, not a shop-floor one.

Software proficiency	High
Manufacturing depth	High
Tolerance for slow UI	Low

IN THEIR WORDS

“If I can copy a template and be done in three minutes instead of twenty, that's the difference between quoting ten jobs today or three.”

WHAT DRIVES THEM — AND WHAT GETS IN THE WAY

The lens Product & Design should hold when building for this user: what they're trying to achieve, where the current experience fails them, and what they need from the product to succeed.

● GOALS

- Quote fast without sacrificing accuracy — speed wins the job.
- Build the estimate once, well, so planning inherits it with no rework.
- Price to protect margin while staying competitive in the market.
- Reduce reliance on the tribal knowledge of retiring machinists.

● FRUSTRATIONS

- Incomplete prints force guesswork — a missing thread call-out can swing cost.
- RFQ intake and quote logging happen *outside* the system, so there's no audit trail.
- Waiting on vendor pricing for material and outside processing stalls turnaround.
- Quoting isn't billable, so effort must be rationed by how likely the job is to land.

● NEEDS FROM PROSHOP

- Fast template reuse — clone a past estimate and adjust, don't rebuild.
- A quoting workspace that keeps the bid/no-bid log *inside* the system.
- Cost roll-ups that update live as material, OSP, and markup change.
- A clean handoff so a won quote becomes a work order with zero re-entry.

THE NUMBERS THEY'RE MEASURED ON

Win rate

Per client. Too low means wasted effort; too high can mean underpricing.

Turnaround

Speed from RFQ received to quote sent — often the deciding factor.

< 30%

Material + services as a share of part price, kept well controlled.

Accuracy

Estimated cost & time vs. what the job actually takes once it runs.

PROSHOP MODULES THEY LIVE IN

Estimating & Quoting **HOME**

Sales & Work Orders **HOME**

Shop Floor & Scheduling **READS**

Job Costing & Financial Data **READS**

Inventory & Material Planning **READS**

WHERE THEY SIT IN THE FLOW

UPSTREAM

Customer

Submits an RFQ with prints, models & specs

RFQ



THIS PERSONA

The Estimator

Scopes, costs & prices the job; sends the quote

WON QUOTE



DOWNSTREAM

Order Entry

Turns the won estimate into a work order

The estimate carries directly into the work order — no re-entry. Every assumption the Estimator makes here becomes a target the Operator is later measured against, and feeds back into future quotes.

*Speed target reflects template-based quoting; from-scratch estimates take substantially longer. Source: ProShop persona sessions + product docs.